



SyncThink for athletes

SyncThink is a new device that uses VR to help understand concussions in athletes with more accuracy. <http://dgit.in/SyncThnkv>



Slack takes on Skype

Slack, the workplace collaboration platform now has built-in video calling and supports emojis. <http://dgit.in/SlacksVcall>

Feature

much deeper messaging integration, this makes for at least one compelling reason to get your hands on a wearable next year.

Lessons Learned: Android Wear and usability

Considering, though, that most smartwatches out on the market run hardware that was top-spec for a 2010-11 era smartphone, isn't there a more straightforward way of getting past software limitations? Let's go back to 2011 and the little-known story of the MOTOACTV. The 360 isn't the first mainstream smartwatch to hit the market. But, strangely enough, it's not even Motorola's first smartwatch. That honour goes to the MOTOACTV. Back in 2011, Motorola decided, for some reason, to out what was essentially a 1-inch Android tablet with a wrist strap. The MOTOACTV ran full-fat Android, and could handle just about any Android app you threw at it. The problem was that menu items were shrunk to unusable proportions, making the watch unsuitable for just about anything apart from Watch and fitness functionality. Which is probably why it didn't sell so well. And by extension why Android Wear is as simplified as it is.

When we put smartwatches in the context of an IoT-enabled world, this is a major concern. The watch, if its role is to be taken seriously, needs to be a hub device. It needs to let the user communicate with multiple devices

at the same time. Without some form of multitasking support at the OS level, an Android Wear smartwatch would simply not be capable of acting as an effective IoT hub. A problem that's much harder to solve, though, is consumer apathy: As of Q3 2016, smartwatch sales are down to around 2.7 million units, a substantial decline from the 5.6 million units shipped in the same period last year. This is a fraction of a fraction of smartphone sales, or even just watch sales for the same time period. Without a large user base, big-name developers tend not to release content for the platform. Without content, users don't see the need to buy into the platform, and the platform developer doesn't see the need in improving the platform itself. A fundamental rewrite of Android Wear—going far beyond the Wear 2.0 paradigm, allowing for true multitasking (not just semi-persistent music player control) and a feature-rich interface—could remedy these issues, but as is always the case, it's demand that shapes products, and right now, there's just not that kind of demand in the market.

A wearable future?

Where could wearables go from here, though? Although the current crop of smartwatches is less than useful, we don't think that wearables, as a category, are a complete write-off. Looking to sci-fi (which, by the way, is turning out to be a remarkably accurate way of predicting the near future), smart eyewear is likely what's next on the horizon. Google Glass never did pick up, even as a concept. It faced many of the same issues faced by Android Wear devices today, only magnified: Glass was never a market-ready product, and the high price of the "Explorer Edition" put off most would-be buyers right off the bat. A dearth of Glass-enabled apps (of which there are fewer than 100) meant that there just wasn't much you could do with your Glass unit. One of these is titled "Google Glass Airplane Mode," which should give you an idea of the state of Glass's app environment. But just like with Android Wear today,

the real killer was Glass's lack of purpose. If a Wear device is a scaled-down second screen for your phone, Google Glass is merely a blown up, head-mounted screen for the same. Moreover, the very real privacy concerns that Glass introduced can't be understated, with casinos and theatres banning its use. While security concerns with smartwatches aren't quite as in-your-face, many people simply remain uncomfortable with the idea of easily concealable wearables being misused.

Nevertheless, with products like Microsoft's HoloLens and the myste-



Google Glass never made it

rious Magic Leap adopting the eyewear form factor, and with the current flourishing of consumer VR, we'd be hard-put to identify where else the wearable story could go.

Although sales are, indeed, in decline, we find it hard to see smartwatches disappearing as a product category anytime soon. There's just something evocative about consumer tech that just blends into the rest of your life. At times, using an Android Wear device like the Moto 360 can feel like a burden: too much effort, too little payoff. But the way it just is, somehow a watch and yet not, the way it takes the familiar and inverts it, evokes the way sci-fi technology once appeared, years ago. It's the familiar masking something new, and that's the real beauty of the IoT, a dusty, scrappy Internet of wardrobes and induction cookers and venetian blinds. And watches. **[1]**



Huawei Watch Classic Style